THE HOUSE OF IDEAS

CHAPTER TWO

“ASSEMBLY REQUIRED”

October 17, 2006 – March 12, 2007
Los Angeles, California

An Alternate-History Hollywood Saga

FADE IN:

INT. MARVEL STUDIOS - FEIGE'S OFFICE - BEVERLY HILLS - DAY

SUPER: TUESDAY, OCTOBER 17, 2006 - 1:30 P.M. PDT

Rain streaks the window, rare for October. KEVIN FEIGE (33) and JON FAVREAU (39) huddle over a speakerphone. LENORA HAYES (41) stands with a signed deal memo in one hand and a BlackBerry in the other.

LENORA
It's done. Terrence Howard is James Rhodes. Fresh off an Oscar nomination, and he's the first actor we've signed who doesn't come with a lunchbox.

FAVREAU
Be nice. The lunchbox kid is gonna carry this movie.

LENORA
(drily)
The lunchbox kid is being paid less than his co-star. For the record. I want that in writing somewhere, because one day someone is going to ask me how that happened.

FEIGE
Marc asked for it that way. He said, and I quote, "Pay Rhodey like the Air Force pays generals."

LENORA
The Air Force does not pay generals that much.

The speakerphone crackles. A smooth, musical voice.

TERRENCE HOWARD (V.O.)
Hello? Kevin? Jon? This is Colonel Rhodes reporting for duty.

TERRENCE HOWARD (37), calling from a car somewhere in the rain.

FAVREAU
Terrence! Welcome to the Air Force, man.

TERRENCE HOWARD (V.O.)
I've been reading the comics all week. You know Rhodey wore the armor before anybody thought a Black man could wear the armor? 1983. Iron Man #170. I've got it in a bag on my dashboard.

FEIGE
(lighting up)
You read #170?

TERRENCE HOWARD (V.O.)
I read #170 twice. And I gotta tell you, when they told me who's playing Tony, I laughed. Not a mean laugh. A happy laugh. Two Black men in two suits of armor in the same movie? That's 1983 and 2008 shaking hands.

FAVREAU
He's gonna call you. He's been trying to figure out how to make it not weird.

TERRENCE HOWARD (V.O.)
Tell him it's already weird. That's the fun part.

Feige's other line is blinking. He glances at it: MARC - CELL. He patches it in.

MARC-ANTHONY (V.O.)
(overlapping, excited)
Is he on? Is Rhodey on? Hi, Colonel, it's Tony, I've been told you're my best friend.

TERRENCE HOWARD (V.O.)
(laughing)
Kid Mayor! My nephew used to make me watch your show.

MARC-ANTHONY (V.O.)
Did he like it?

TERRENCE HOWARD (V.O.)
He liked it. I loved it. Don't tell anybody.

MARC-ANTHONY BULLOCK (24) is driving down Sunset with Bluetooth in his ear, grinning like a kid.

MARC-ANTHONY (V.O.)
I'm gonna be the worst-behaved best friend you ever had, Terrence.

TERRENCE HOWARD (V.O.)
And I'm gonna be the one who always comes to get you. That's Rhodey. He always comes.

Silence for a beat. Lenora quietly puts down her BlackBerry. Even she's moved.

VARIETY - WED OCT 18, 2006

HOWARD TO FLY WITH 'IRON MAN'

Oscar nominee ("Hustle & Flow") will play Col. James Rhodes opposite Marc-Anthony Bullock in Marvel's self-financed tentpole. Insiders say Howard's deal is the richest on the picture.

SUPERHEROHYPE.COM - THREAD: "TERRENCE HOWARD IS RHODEY!!!" (Page 1 of 22)

WarMachineRox (Oct 18, 9:12 AM)
I HAVE WAITED MY ENTIRE LIFE FOR THIS. War Machine in a Marvel movie. They're really doing it.

ShellHead1963 (Oct 18, 9:20 AM)
Ok. OK. Oscar nominee. This is a serious cast. I'm... cautiously less mad.

NoNerfsPlz (Oct 18, 9:24 AM)
"Nobody gets nerfed" + War Machine = I need to lie down

Repulsor_Ray (Oct 18, 9:31 AM)
so the kid takes scale and terrence gets the big check. marc-anthony bullock is either a saint or playing 4D chess

CUT TO:

INT. STAN WINSTON STUDIO - WORKSHOP - VAN NUYS - DAY

SUPER: THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 16, 2006 - 10:00 A.M. PST

A cathedral of monsters. A full-size T-Rex head from JURASSIC PARK. A Terminator endoskeleton. The Predator's mask. And in the middle of the floor, under a tarp, something shaped like a man.

STAN WINSTON (60), a legend in a sweater vest, stands beside the tarp with the calm of a man who has built every nightmare of the last thirty years. Favreau, Feige and Marc-Anthony stand in front of him. Also present: ADI GRANOV, the Bosnian-born artist whose IRON MAN: EXTREMIS covers redefined the armor, holding a portfolio.

STAN WINSTON
Kevin sent me a memo. Do you want to know what it said?

FEIGE
(sheepish)
I have a feeling you're going to tell me.

STAN WINSTON
(pulling a folded paper from his pocket)
"Faithful to the source material. No nerfing." I had to ask my grandson what "nerfing" meant. He told me it means making something weaker so it's fair.

(beat)
Kevin. I have never in my life made anything weaker so it's fair.

He pulls the tarp off.

THE MARK I ARMOR. Gray, hammered, bolted, riveted. Ugly and beautiful. Straight out of TALES OF SUSPENSE #39, Jack Kirby and Don Heck's original design, built in steel.

Marc-Anthony stops breathing. He walks toward it slowly, the way you walk toward an altar.

MARC-ANTHONY
(whisper)
It's 1963.

ADI GRANOV
It's 1963 if you were building it in a cave with a car battery. That was my only rule. Every bolt has to look like Tony could have welded it with a blowtorch and a grudge.

MARC-ANTHONY
Can I touch it?

STAN WINSTON
You can wear it. It weighs ninety pounds. You'll hate me by lunch.

MARC-ANTHONY
Mr. Winston, I'm going to love you by lunch and hate you by dinner.

Granov opens his portfolio. Page after page of concept art: the Mark II, silver and sleek. The Mark III, red and gold. Every line traceable to the comics.

ADI GRANOV
Mark III is the classic. I took the faceplate from my EXTREMIS design and the color from the 1960s. Gold where Kirby put gold. Red where Ditko put red.

FAVREAU
Can he fly in it?

STAN WINSTON
In my shop he walks in it. ILM makes him fly. Between the two of us, nobody will know where the man stops and the machine starts.

Marc-Anthony puts a hand on the Mark I's chest plate, where the arc reactor will glow.

MARC-ANTHONY
(quietly)
Mr. Winston? Thank you. For not making it fair.

Stan Winston looks at the young man for a long moment. Then he smiles.

STAN WINSTON
Kid, I've been waiting thirty years for somebody to build this right.

CUT TO:

INT. SMILLEY ESTATE - DESMOND'S STUDY - VIEW PARK - NIGHT

SUPER: FRIDAY, DECEMBER 15, 2006 - 9:40 P.M. PST

Christmas lights in the windows. DESMOND SMILLEY (49) sits behind his desk. Across from him, a rumpled private investigator, RUSS KESSLER (52), slides a thick manila folder across the leather.

RUSS
Eleven weeks. Six of my best people. I've done senators. I've done studio heads. I did a bishop once.

DESMOND
And?

RUSS
And nothing. Your boy is clean.

Desmond opens the folder. Russ rattles off the highlights like a grocery list he hates.

RUSS (CONT'D)
No arrests. No DUIs. No drugs. Pays his taxes early. Three ex-girlfriends in seven years, and all three still send him birthday cards. He tipped a valet five hundred dollars because the kid's mom was sick. He pays the full tuition of his childhood stunt double's daughter at Spelman. He visits Children's Hospital every other Tuesday in a hat and sunglasses and thinks nobody knows.

DESMOND
(cold)
Everybody has something.

RUSS
With respect, Mr. Smilley, this guy's "something" is that he once returned a library book late in 1998. And he paid the fine, plus a donation to the library.

Desmond closes the folder slowly.

DESMOND
Then we stop looking at him.

RUSS
Meaning?

DESMOND
Meaning a man that clean has no armor. He just has people. The people around him. The best friend, the Baker kid. The co-star, the Boyd girl. Who's he going to fight for? Who's he going to protect?

(beat)
Find out who he loves, Russ.

Russ shifts uncomfortably.

RUSS
Mr. Smilley, I'll be honest. Taking that job makes me feel like the bad guy.

DESMOND
(a thin smile)
Every story needs one. I'll pay you double.

Through the crack in the study door, unseen, SIMONE SMILLEY (27) has heard everything. She backs away silently, pulls out her Sidekick, and starts typing a text. Then she stops. Deletes it. Puts the phone away. Not yet.

CUT TO:

EXT. JEFF BRIDGES' RANCH - SANTA BARBARA COUNTY - DAY

SUPER: WEDNESDAY, JANUARY 10, 2007 - 2:00 P.M. PST

Golden hills. Horses. JEFF BRIDGES (57), effortlessly cool in a flannel and his signature long hair, sits on a porch swing beside Favreau, an IRON MAN script on his lap with a hundred sticky notes poking out.

BRIDGES
So this Obadiah cat. In the comic. He's bald, right?

FAVREAU
Shaved head. Big beard. Smokes cigars. Plays chess with real people.

BRIDGES
And your boss says it's gotta be like the book.

FAVREAU
Kevin's got it laminated on his wall. "Faithful. Nobody nerfed." The Iron Monger suit's gonna be bigger than a minivan.

BRIDGES
(running a hand through his hair, considering)
Huh.

A long, Bridges-style pause. A horse whinnies.

BRIDGES (CONT'D)
You got any clippers, man?

FAVREAU
...Right now?

BRIDGES
Nah. Not right now. My wife would kill me. But I'll do it. If the book says bald, the Dude abides.

THE HOLLYWOOD REPORTER - THU JAN 11, 2007

BRIDGES TO GO BALD FOR 'IRON MAN'

Oscar nominee will play Obadiah Stane, Tony Stark's mentor turned enemy. "The Iron Monger is a beast in the comics. That's what they asked for," says a Marvel source.

AIN'T IT COOL NEWS - TALKBACK: "THE DUDE IS IRON MONGER" (764 comments)

Gorgo_The_Mighty (Jan 11, 10:04 AM)
JEFF BRIDGES. BALD. IRON MONGER. Remember when we said Marvel was going to blow it? I was wrong. I'm a man. I admit it.

Old_Man_Logan_Fan (Jan 11, 10:09 AM)
Marvel's casting serious actors and promising comic accuracy. Fox is sweating somewhere in Century City.

first! (Jan 11, 10:10 AM)
first

ElektraWasAMistake (Jan 11, 10:15 AM)
Now cast Pepper and don't screw it up. No supermodels. Pepper is smart, funny, and she runs the company.

CUT TO:

INT. STARDISH.COM - HOMEPAGE - NIGHT

SUPER: THURSDAY, FEBRUARY 1, 2007 - 11:48 P.M. PST

STARDISH.COM - "BLIND ITEMS AND BLAZING HOT GOSSIP" - FEB 1, 2007, 11:48 PM

EXCLUSIVE: IRON MAN'S "TAB" GOES TO HIS HEAD?

A well-placed source tells StarDish that Marc-Anthony Bullock is "demanding" that Marvel cast his childhood co-star Tayia Boyd as Pepper Potts, even though the studio wants an A-list actress. "He's using his family's name to get his friends jobs," our source says. "Nothing says 'nobody gets nerfed' like a little nepotism, right?"

Boyd, 24, hasn't had a steady job since her Donohue Channel days...

Comments (1,031)

FADE OUT. FADE IN:

INT. RALEIGH STUDIOS - REHEARSAL HALL - HOLLYWOOD - DAY

SUPER: FRIDAY, FEBRUARY 2, 2007 - 11:00 A.M. PST

Fluorescent lights. Folding chairs. A coffee urn that tastes like a stapler. SARAH FINN, Marvel's casting director, sits with Favreau and Feige behind a table stacked with headshots of the most famous actresses in Hollywood.

Marc-Anthony (25) paces by the window, furious, holding a printout of the StarDish item.

MARC-ANTHONY
I never said a word. Not one word. I have never called anybody about Tayia. You know I didn't.

FAVREAU
I know, man.

MARC-ANTHONY
Somebody wants her to walk in here and have everybody think she's the boss's buddy. That's cruel. That's so cruel, Jon. She's been waiting two years for one audition.

FEIGE
Marc. Look at me. If she's the best Pepper, she's Pepper. If she isn't, she isn't. That's the only thing that happens in this room. A blog doesn't get a vote.

Marc-Anthony nods, swallowing it down. Lenora sticks her head in the door.

LENORA
She's here. And for the record, legal's preparing a statement on the StarDish item. Whoever leaked that knew the audition schedule.

FAVREAU
Which means somebody's talking.

LENORA
Which means somebody's paying somebody to talk.

She exits. The door opens again. TAYIA BOYD (24) walks in, wearing a sharp navy pantsuit and an expression that says she knows exactly what everyone read last night. She stops in front of the table.

TAYIA
Good morning. Before we start, I'd like to say one thing.

FAVREAU
Please.

TAYIA
I didn't ask him for anything. He didn't ask you for anything. And if I'm not the best person you see this week, I want you to give it to whoever is. Because I'm not here to be his friend. I'm here to be Pepper Potts.

Silence. Sarah Finn writes something on her notepad and underlines it twice.

FAVREAU
...Okay. From the top. Tony's lost his schedule and you've been up since four.

Marc-Anthony steps into position. Then he and Tayia look at each other, and twelve years of shared history snap into place like a magnetic lock.

MARC-ANTHONY (AS TONY)
Pepper. Where am I supposed to be right now?

TAYIA (AS PEPPER)
Forty minutes ago? MIT. Commencement speech. You're receiving an honorary doctorate.

MARC-ANTHONY (AS TONY)
I already have a doctorate.

TAYIA (AS PEPPER)
You have three. They wanted to give you a fourth to make you stop calling them.

MARC-ANTHONY (AS TONY)
(off script)
Did I ever thank you for, you know, everything?

TAYIA (AS PEPPER)
(off script, instantly)
Twice. Once in 2003, and once when you thought you were dying from that clam chowder.

MARC-ANTHONY (AS TONY)
It was bad chowder, Pepper.

TAYIA (AS PEPPER)
It was a paper cut, Tony.

Favreau bites his knuckle to keep from laughing. Feige isn't even pretending; he's grinning. Sarah Finn has stopped writing and is just watching.

TAYIA (AS PEPPER) (CONT'D)
(softer, the real scene now)
You know what you need? You need someone who isn't afraid of you. Everyone in this building is afraid of you. I'm just afraid FOR you. There's a difference.

Marc-Anthony looks at her, and for a moment it isn't acting. It's twelve years of a kids' set, of growing up next to someone.

FAVREAU
(quietly)
...Cut.

A long beat. Feige leans over to Sarah Finn and whispers. She nods.

SARAH FINN
Thank you, Tayia. We'll be in touch.

Tayia nods professionally, turns, and walks out. As soon as the door shuts behind her, they hear one small, muffled scream from the hallway. Everyone in the room pretends not to.

CUT TO:

INT. TAYIA'S MOTHER'S HOUSE - KITCHEN - INGLEWOOD - DAY

SUPER: SATURDAY, FEBRUARY 3, 2007 - 10:15 A.M. PST

A warm, cluttered kitchen. Balloons: "HAPPY 25TH TAYIA!" Her mother, MS. LORRAINE BOYD (54), a school librarian, is frosting a lopsided red velvet cake. Tayia, now 25, sits at the table in a bathrobe, scrolling the StarDish comments on a laptop.

LORRAINE
Close that computer. It's your birthday. Nobody reads gossip on their birthday.

TAYIA
Somebody named "PepperIsTaken" says I look like a "budget Pepper."

LORRAINE
Budget Pepper got her own show at thirteen and paid off my car. Close it.

Tayia's flip phone rings. Unknown number with a 310 area code. She stares at it.

LORRAINE (CONT'D)
Well, answer it! Lord.

TAYIA
(answering)
Hello?

FAVREAU (V.O.)
Tayia, it's Jon Favreau. I hear it's somebody's birthday.

Tayia stands up so fast her chair falls over.

FAVREAU (V.O.) (CONT'D)
I didn't get you a present. But I got you a job. You're Pepper Potts, kid. Unanimous. Kevin, me, Sarah, Avi. Avi wanted to fight about it and then he couldn't think of a reason.

Tayia drops to her knees on the kitchen floor. Lorraine drops the frosting knife.

TAYIA
(sobbing, laughing)
Thank you. Thank you. I won't... I'm gonna...

FAVREAU (V.O.)
And Tayia? You earned this in that room. Not on a blog, not over a phone. In that room. Don't ever let anybody tell you different.

Click. Tayia looks up at her mother. Lorraine is crying too, cake frosting on her face.

LORRAINE
Budget Pepper?

TAYIA
Pepper Potts, Mama. Just Pepper Potts.

They collapse into each other's arms on the kitchen floor.

CUT TO:

INT. MARC-ANTHONY'S HOUSE - LIVING ROOM - LOS FELIZ - NIGHT

SUPER: SUNDAY, FEBRUARY 4, 2007 - 4:55 P.M. PST

A Super Bowl party. SUPER BOWL XLI, Colts vs. Bears, is on a giant plasma screen. PRINCE is performing "Purple Rain" at halftime in the actual rain in Miami. Guests crowd the couches: AMOND BAKER (24), GRACE BULLOCK (12), ELXA BULLOCK (26), college friends, the KID MAYOR prop master. Tayia walks in carrying her leftover birthday cake. The room ERUPTS.

AMOND
PEPPER POTTS IN THE BUILDING!

GRACE
Can I have your autograph? Can I sell it on eBay?

TAYIA
No and no!

Marc-Anthony crosses the room and wraps her in a hug that lifts her off the ground.

MARC-ANTHONY
I told you. Trilogy.

TAYIA
(in his ear)
You didn't call them, right? Swear to me.

MARC-ANTHONY
On J.T. Tate's grave. I didn't say a word. You did it.

She pulls back, relieved. On TV, Prince shreds a guitar solo in the pouring rain. Everyone turns to watch.

ELXA
(watching, wistful)
That's what it looks like when nobody can stop you.

Marc-Anthony glances at his sister. He notices the sadness under the smile. He files it away.

CUT TO:

INT. DU-PAR'S RESTAURANT - STUDIO CITY - DAY

SUPER: TUESDAY, FEBRUARY 20, 2007 - 7:30 A.M. PST

An old-school diner. Pancakes the size of hubcaps. In a back booth, Feige sits across from Elxa Bullock, who is wearing a baseball cap and no makeup. A Marvel NDA sits between the coffee cups.

ELXA
You said this was a secret. A secret secret.

FEIGE
The most secret thing at Marvel. There are four people who know about it, and one of them is Stan Lee, so honestly it's a miracle.

He slides a single page across the table. A character sheet. A sketch: a woman in a sleek gold and black costume with translucent wings.

ELXA
(reading)
"Janet van Dyne." The Wasp?

FEIGE
Founding Avenger. She named the team in AVENGERS #1. 1963. We're making ANT-MAN. Edgar Wright's directing. It comes out in 2009. But Jon is shooting a gala at the Donohue Concert Hall in April, and Tony Stark is going to flirt with a gorgeous fashion-designer heiress for about thirty seconds. Most of the audience won't know who she is. The fans will lose their minds.

ELXA
(carefully)
Kevin. My mother has a rule. No family in Donohue productions.

FEIGE
This isn't a Donohue production. It's a Marvel production, distributed by Paramount. And I'm not offering you the part.

ELXA
(deflating)
...Oh.

FEIGE
I'm offering you an audition. Just like everyone else. You come in, you read, and if you're Janet, you're Janet. If not, we buy your pancakes and pretend this never happened.

Elxa looks down at the sketch. Her hands are shaking slightly. For two years every door has been closed to her because of her last name. Now someone is offering her a fair shot.

ELXA
Does my brother know?

FEIGE
Your brother doesn't know. And he can't know until we decide. If you get it, I want everybody in Hollywood to know he had nothing to do with it.

ELXA
(a slow smile)
Give me the pen.

She signs the NDA.

CUT TO:

INT. MARVEL STUDIOS - FEIGE'S OFFICE - BEVERLY HILLS - NIGHT

SUPER: FRIDAY, FEBRUARY 23, 2007 - 8:10 P.M. PST

The office is empty except for Feige. He takes a deep breath and dials a number on his cell. It rings twice.

SAMUEL L. JACKSON (V.O.)
Yeah.

FEIGE
Mr. Jackson, this is Kevin Feige at Marvel Studios. I apologize for calling so late.

SAMUEL L. JACKSON (V.O.)
Kevin Feige. Marvel. You know they already drew my face on Nick Fury, right? In 2002? Without asking me?

FEIGE
I do know that, sir. That's actually why I'm calling.

A pause on the line. SAMUEL L. JACKSON (58) is listening.

FEIGE (CONT'D)
We'd like to ask you. Officially. One scene, after the credits of IRON MAN. And then, if you're willing, a lot more.

SAMUEL L. JACKSON (V.O.)
A lot more like what?

FEIGE
Like nine pictures.

A long silence. Then a rolling, delighted laugh.

SAMUEL L. JACKSON (V.O.)
Nine pictures. You crazy. I like crazy. And I heard about this "nobody gets nerfed" thing. That means Fury gets to be Fury? Eyepatch, cigar, smartest motherfucker in every room?

FEIGE
The smartest one in every room, yes, sir.

SAMUEL L. JACKSON (V.O.)
Have your people call my people. And Kevin? Who's the kid playing Stark?

FEIGE
Marc-Anthony Bullock.

SAMUEL L. JACKSON (V.O.)
The Kid Mayor? Hm.

(beat)
My granddaughter's gonna lose her mind.

CUT TO:

EXT. RALEIGH MANHATTAN BEACH STUDIOS - EL SEGUNDO/MANHATTAN BEACH - DAWN

SUPER: MONDAY, MARCH 12, 2007 - 5:55 A.M. PDT

First light over the Pacific. Fourteen massive soundstages. Trailers, grip trucks, catering tents, and a gate sign: "STAGE 7 - CLOSED SET - IRON MAN."

INT. STAGE 7 - THE CAVE SET - CONTINUOUS

A full-scale Afghan cave, smoky and lit by hanging bulbs. A workbench covered in scrap metal, missile parts, blowtorches. Crew members move silently. In the corner, under work lights, the MARK I ARMOR stands waiting.

Marc-Anthony sits in a makeup chair, half-built: a scruffy beard, a scar on his forehead, and a prototype ARC REACTOR glowing blue in his chest. He is murmuring lines to himself. TERRENCE HOWARD (38), in an Air Force flight suit, sits beside him with a coffee.

TERRENCE HOWARD
You nervous?

MARC-ANTHONY
Terrified. I've done a hundred first days. This one feels like the first first day.

TERRENCE HOWARD
Good. The day you're not nervous is the day you've stopped caring. Just remember one thing.

MARC-ANTHONY
What?

TERRENCE HOWARD
(standing, squeezing his shoulder)
Rhodey always comes to get you.

Favreau appears, headset on, bouncing on his toes like a Little League coach.

FAVREAU
Okay, everybody. Day one. We are shooting the cave. Marc, you've been kidnapped, you've got shrapnel next to your heart, and you're about to build the most important machine in the history of the world out of garbage. No pressure.

Laughter from the crew. Stan Winston stands by the monitor, arms crossed, watching his armor.

FAVREAU (CONT'D)
Roll sound.

SOUND MIXER
Speed.

CAMERA OPERATOR
Rolling.

SECOND AC
IRON MAN, scene four, take one. Mark it.

CLAP.

FAVREAU
...And action.

Marc-Anthony picks up a blowtorch. His hands are shaking just the right amount. He looks at a piece of scrap metal and something behind his eyes switches on, the look of a genius seeing a solution nobody else can see.

MARC-ANTHONY (AS TONY)
(to himself, quietly)
Okay. Okay, Tony. Make something.

He ignites the torch. Blue flame. Sparks fly. The camera pushes in slowly on his face, lit by fire and the glow of the arc reactor.

Behind the monitor, Feige squeezes the comic book in his jacket pocket. Stan Winston uncrosses his arms.

STAN WINSTON
(softly, to no one)
There he is.

CUT TO:

INT. MARVEL ENTERTAINMENT - NEWS WIRE - DAY

SUPER: MONDAY, MARCH 12, 2007 - 9:00 A.M. PDT

MARVEL ENTERTAINMENT, INC. - PRESS RELEASE - MONDAY, MARCH 12, 2007, 9:00 AM PT

MARVEL STUDIOS BEGINS PRINCIPAL PHOTOGRAPHY ON "IRON MAN"

Full Cast and Creative Team Announced for May 2, 2008 Release

LOS ANGELES - Marvel Studios today began principal photography on IRON MAN, directed by Jon Favreau, at Raleigh Manhattan Beach Studios in California, with additional filming planned at Edwards Air Force Base and in the Lone Pine area.

CAST: Marc-Anthony Bullock (Tony Stark / Iron Man), Terrence Howard (Lt. Col. James "Rhodey" Rhodes), Jeff Bridges (Obadiah Stane / Iron Monger), Tayia Boyd (Virginia "Pepper" Potts), Shaun Toub (Ho Yinsen), Faran Tahir (Raza), Leslie Bibb (Christine Everhart), Clark Gregg (Agent Phil Coulson), Bill Smitrovich (General Gabriel), and Jon Favreau (Harold "Happy" Hogan).

CREATIVE TEAM: Directed by Jon Favreau. Screenplay by Mark Fergus & Hawk Ostby and Art Marcum & Matt Holloway. Produced by Avi Arad and Kevin Feige. Executive producers: Louis D'Esposito, Peter Billingsley, Ari Arad, Stan Lee, David Maisel and Jon Favreau. Director of photography: Matthew Libatique. Production designer: J. Michael Riva. Costume designer: Laura Jean Shannon. Editor: Dan Lebental. Armor designed and built by Stan Winston Studio. Visual effects by Industrial Light & Magic. Concept design by Adi Granov.

"Every person on this list was chosen because they understood one thing: we are making the real Iron Man," said Kevin Feige. "The armor comes from the comics. The characters come from the comics. Obadiah Stane, Ho Yinsen, Pepper, Rhodey and Happy have been in these books for decades. Fans are going to see them exactly as they imagined them, at full power."

"I've worked with Marc-Anthony and Tayia since the day we started casting, and I've never seen two actors take a coffee-stained rehearsal hall and turn it into a movie," said Favreau. "Wait until you see what this cast does."

MONTAGE - THE WORLD REACTS

SUPER: MONDAY, MARCH 12, 2007 - THROUGHOUT THE DAY

VARIETY - MON MARCH 12, 2007

'IRON MAN' REVS UP WITH BOYD AS PEPPER

Marvel rounds out its cast with Bullock's former Donohue Channel co-star; sources say the audition was "unanimous." Studio officially denies any lobbying by its star. Bridges, Howard top a heavyweight supporting lineup.

ENTERTAINMENT WEEKLY - EW.COM - "THE HOLLYWOOD INSIDER"

Pepper Potts Has Been Cast, and the Internet Is Very Happy About It

Tayia Boyd, 25, beat out several A-listers for Marvel's leading lady. "She walked in after the worst week of gossip of her life and owned the room," says a source.

SUPERHEROHYPE.COM - THREAD: "OFFICIAL: FULL IRON MAN CAST + CREW - PRODUCTION BEGINS" (Page 1 of 63)

ElektraWasAMistake (Mar 12, 9:14 AM)
Ho Yinsen. HO. YINSEN. They used his real comic name. Stan Winston on the armor. Adi Granov concept art. These people actually read the books.

PepperIsTaken (Mar 12, 9:20 AM)
ok I said "budget Pepper" a month ago and I would like to formally apologize. She beat A-LISTERS? Unanimous? I'm a clown.

NoNerfsPlz (Mar 12, 9:22 AM)
Favreau as HAPPY HOGAN. The director is playing the chauffeur. That's the most comic-book thing I've ever heard.

ShellHead1963 (Mar 12, 9:41 AM)
I've been on this board since 2001. I've hated every Marvel movie announcement since 2003. I just want to say: this is the first time I'm excited. Don't let me down, Kid Mayor.

WarMachineRox (Mar 12, 9:43 AM)
"Rhodey always comes to get you." Terrence said that in an interview on BET this morning. I'm not crying, you're crying.

TWITTER.COM - PUBLIC TIMELINE (Twitter is the breakout hit of this week's South by Southwest festival in Austin)

geekgirl_atx: sitting in a sxsw panel and literally everyone is refreshing superherohype. iron man started shooting today!! 9:32 AM Mar 12th from web

comicshopdan: customer just bought every copy of tales of suspense #39 reprint we had. thanks marvel. 10:05 AM Mar 12th from txt

tayiaboyd: pepper potts reporting for duty. thank you for believing in me. and to my mama: yes I'm wearing a coat. 11:20 AM Mar 12th from web

MYSPACE.COM - TAYIA BOYD (OFFICIAL) - BULLETIN - MON MARCH 12, 2007

Subject: to everybody who called me "budget pepper"

thank you! you motivated me more than any coffee ever could. see you May 2, 2008. love, Pepper

Comments (11,226) | Kudos (34,581)

CUT TO:

INT. SMILLEY ESTATE - LIVING ROOM - VIEW PARK - DAY

SUPER: MONDAY, MARCH 12, 2007 - 12:30 P.M. PDT

Desmond reads VARIETY at the kitchen island. The word "unanimous" might as well be printed in blood. Celeste stands at the stove making tea. ESTHER (24) sits at the table pretending to read a script her parents approved: a faith-based musical called "HALLELUJAH HOLIDAY."

DESMOND
(quietly)
Unanimous.

CELESTE
Desmond, let it go. It's a cartoon movie about a robot.

DESMOND
It's the beginning of everything, Celeste. That family is building a cathedral in plain sight and everybody is applauding the bricks.

Simone enters, eating an apple, and drops onto the couch.

SIMONE
Funny thing about that StarDish item. Somebody leaked the audition schedule, but it was supposed to be confidential. Marvel's lawyers are looking into it. I hear they're very good lawyers.

Desmond's jaw tightens. He doesn't look at her. Celeste looks between them, confused.

CELESTE
What does that have to do with anything?

SIMONE
(sweetly)
Nothing, Mama. Just making conversation.

Esther's phone buzzes in her lap under the table. She glances down.

TEXT MESSAGE - "MAYOR" TO ESTHER

MON 3/12/07 12:31 PM

first day done. i built a robot out of garbage. ur dad would be so disappointed in me lol. how is hallelujah holiday

Esther suppresses a smile and types under the table.

TEXT MESSAGE - ESTHER TO "MAYOR"

MON 3/12/07 12:33 PM

its a musical about a choir that saves christmas. in july. i play a nun who sings to a goat. please come rescue me in ur robot suit

She deletes the thread. Across the room, Simone watches her little sister's face, and for a split second, Simone smiles. She knows.

CUT TO:

EXT. RALEIGH MANHATTAN BEACH STUDIOS - BACKLOT - NIGHT

SUPER: MONDAY, MARCH 12, 2007 - 9:15 P.M. PDT

Wrap. The crew is loading out. Marc-Anthony, Tayia and Terrence sit on apple boxes outside Stage 7, eating cold pizza from craft services, exhausted and happy. The arc reactor prop still glows faintly under Marc's T-shirt.

TAYIA
You know what the craziest thing about today was?

MARC-ANTHONY
That Jeff Bridges came to set just to watch and brought everyone pie?

TAYIA
No. Well, yes. But no. The craziest thing is that nobody on that stage looked at you like a kid. Not once.

Marc-Anthony goes quiet. He looks at the glow under his shirt.

TERRENCE HOWARD
That's 'cause you stopped being one about five minutes after Jon said "action."

Marc-Anthony's phone buzzes. It's AMOND. He puts it on speaker.

AMOND (V.O.)
Tell me you're not busy. Tell me you're eating garbage pizza in a parking lot so I don't feel bad.

MARC-ANTHONY
I'm eating garbage pizza in a parking lot with Pepper Potts and War Machine.

AMOND (V.O.)
Hi, Pepper. Hi, War Machine.

TAYIA AND TERRENCE
Hi, Amond!

AMOND (V.O.)
(a deep breath, nervous)
So. The Hulk people called. The new Hulk. Leterrier's movie. They want me to come in. Next month. For Banner.

Marc-Anthony jumps up, spilling his pizza.

MARC-ANTHONY
BRUCE BANNER?

AMOND (V.O.)
It's just a read. They probably want somebody funny to read against the real guy.

MARC-ANTHONY
Mond. Listen to me. They didn't call the funny best friend. They called YOU.

A silence on the line. When Amond speaks again, his voice is thick.

AMOND (V.O.)
...Okay. Okay. I'm gonna go practice being sad.

MARC-ANTHONY
You've been practicing for two years, brother. You're ready.

They hang up. Marc-Anthony looks up at the night sky over the Pacific: the same stars, a whole new universe.

MARC-ANTHONY (CONT'D)
(quietly)
Okay, Tony. Make something.

FADE OUT.

INT. SMILLEY ESTATE - DESMOND'S STUDY - NIGHT

SUPER: MONDAY, MARCH 12, 2007 - 11:44 P.M. PDT

Desmond on the phone, low.

DESMOND
Russ. The co-star didn't work. Marvel lawyered up.

(listening)
No. Forget the girl. The best friend. Baker.

(beat)
I hear he's going in for the Hulk next month. Find out who's casting it, who's producing it, and who owes me a favor at Universal.

He hangs up. On his desk, beside the VARIETY, is a single 1984 JET cover: young Desmond, smiling, the most beautiful man in America. He turns it face down.

SMASH CUT TO BLACK.

END OF CHAPTER TWO